

The Morphosyntactic–Semantic Unity of the Early Middle Japanese Realis Form *Izenkei*: the *-ru* $\approx$ *-re* allomorphy and the so-called *kakari-musubi*

Shinya Makino

itakanro@g.ecc.u-tokyo.ac.jp

Abstract

This study proposes a unified morphosyntactic–semantic account of the suffixal form *-re* found in the Early Middle Japanese realis paradigm — the so-called *izenkei*. It argues first that *-re* is a contextual allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACT(UAL-WORLD-COMMITMENT), 0PAST]. The suffix *-ru* marks a proposition as [+ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world. It surfaces as *-re* when the proposition is set as a premise.

This premise-setting environment is supplied overtly by the conditional suffix *-ba* and the concessive suffix *-do(mo)*, and covertly by the phonologically null suffix $\emptyset$, specified as [+PREM(ISE-SETTING)], in the *=koso* type of *kakari-musubi*. Thus, the particle *=koso* does not itself condition the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re*, but rather focalises a constituent within an already constructed proposition — that is, a proposition marked as [+PREM] by $\emptyset$ and thus serving as a premise. In the *=zo/=namu* type of *kakari-musubi*, by contrast, a topic–comment proposition is first constructed, and a predicate-containing topic constituent is nominalised by $\emptyset$ [+NOM(INAL)]. The proposition is then set as a premise by a further $\emptyset$ [+PREM], after which *=zo* or *=namu* focalises the comment phrase. Although the proposition is thus set as a premise, the intervening $\emptyset$ [+NOM] immediately following *-ru* blocks the local morphological relation between *-ru* and $\emptyset$ [+PREM] required to trigger the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re*. Consequently, *-ru* is not realised as *-re*.

The analysis also accounts for the [+COND(ITIONAL)]-based semantic opposition between the realis forms *-re-ba* [+ACT, 0PAST] and *-sika-ba* [+ACT, +PAST], on the one hand, and the irrealis forms $\emptyset$ -*ba* [−ACT, 0PAST] and *-se-ba* [−ACT, +PAST], on the other. Furthermore, the structural parallelism between verbal and verbal-adjectival realis forms supports the presence of the same underlying *-ru*, realised as *-re* in a premise-setting environment, in both categories. Finally, the loss of productive $\emptyset$ -*ba*, and hence of the productive opposition between *-re-ba* [+ACT, +COND] and $\emptyset$ -*ba* [−ACT, +COND], is proposed to have led to the loss of the [+ACT] value of *-re* and, owing to the resulting semantic and morphological opacity of *-re*, to the reanalysis of *-re-ba* as the single Contemporary Japanese conditional suffix *-reba* [+COND].

1. Introduction

This study argues that the suffixal form *-re* found in the Early Middle Japanese (EMJ) realis paradigm — the so-called *izenkei*, as in *m-i-re-ba* 'since/when one sees', *m-i-re-do(mo)* 'though one sees' and *=koso ... m-i-re* 'one sees ... exactly', from the verb *miru* 'look at; see' — is not an independent inflexional morpheme, but an allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACT(UAL-WORLD-COMMITMENT), 0PAST], selected in premise-setting contexts. The morphosyntactic–semantic environments conditioning the allomorphy *-ru* → *-re* can be schematised as in (1)–(3), where '=' indicates enclisis:

(1) [... *-ru*] + $\emptyset$ [+PREMISE-SETTING]

→ [... *-ru*]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

→ [... *-re*]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

→ [[[... =*koso*]_{FOCUS} + [... *-re*]_{BACKGROUND}]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

(2) [... *-ru*] + *-ba* [+CONDITIONAL]

→ [... *-ru*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [... *-re*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [... *-re*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE} + [...]_{APODOSIS}

(3) [... *-ru*] + *-do(mo)* [+CONCESSIVE]

→ [... *-ru*]-*do(mo)*]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [... *-re*]-*do(mo)*]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [... *-re*]-*do(mo)*]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE} + [...]_{APODOSIS}

In (1), the proposition comprises a potential focus and its background, while the suffix *-ru* marks that proposition as [+ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world. (The [0PAST] value of *-ru* [+ACT, 0PAST] will be addressed in Section 6 through the opposition between [0PAST] and [+PAST] in *-re-ba* and $\emptyset$ -*ba*, on the one hand, and *-sika-ba* and *-se-ba*, on the other, as in *m-i-re-ba* 'since/when one sees' and *m-i- $\emptyset$ -ba* 'if one sees' vs. *m-i-sika-ba* 'since/when one saw' and *m-i-se-ba* 'if one saw' from the aforementioned verb *miru*.) The phonologically null morpheme $\emptyset$ following *-ru*, specified as [+PREM(ISE-SETTING)], then sets that proposition as the premise for the subsequent focalising operation, whereby *=koso* focalises the constituent corresponding

to the potential focus within that proposition. In (2), the suffix *-ba*, specified as [+COND(ITIONAL)], sets as a premise the proposition marked as [+ACT] by *-ru* and presents the eventuality expressed by the apodosis as following naturally — in the light of background knowledge comprising general knowledge, the speech situation and the preceding context — from the eventuality expressed by the protasis. In (3), the suffix *-do(mo)*, specified as [+CONC(ESSIVE)], also sets as a premise the proposition marked as [+ACT] by *-ru*, but presents the eventuality expressed by the apodosis as constituting a consequence contrary to what would ordinarily be expected from that expressed by the protasis. The common conditioning environment can therefore be formulated more simply as in (4):

$$(4) -ru \rightarrow -re / \text{PREMISE-SETTING ENVIRONMENT: } -\emptyset, -ba, -do(mo)$$

In other words, *-re* itself does not mean 'condition', 'concession' or 'background'. Rather, the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re* is triggered when a proposition marked as [+ACT] by *-ru* is incorporated as a premise into another semantic structure: a focus–background structure in the case of *=koso*, a conditional structure in the case of *-ba* and a concessive structure in the case of *-do(mo)*.

Accordingly, with regard to the $[[\dots=koso] + [\dots -re]]$ type of the so-called *kakari-musubi*, the present analysis does not treat *=koso* as selecting the so-called *izenkei* in *-re*, as traditionally assumed. Rather, this allomorphy occurs because the phonologically null morpheme $-\emptyset$ following *-ru*, specified as [+PREM], sets as a premise the proposition marked as [+ACT] by *-ru*, thereby providing the basis for the subsequent focalisation: the particle *=koso* THEN focuses a particular constituent within that premised proposition. As will be discussed in Section 4, the independently attested conditional use of bare realis forms, without *=koso* or an overt connective such as *-ba* or *-do(mo)*, indicates that *=koso* cannot be the sole or defining trigger of *-re* (cf. Ōno et al., 1990: 1497, 1501). Rather, *=koso* participates in one particular premise-setting environment in which *-ru*, specified as [+ACT], has been realised as *-re*.

By contrast, in the $[[\dots =zo/=namu] + [\dots -ru]]$ type of *kakari-musubi*, which ends in the adnominal form of the predicate, a proposition containing a topic–comment information structure is first constructed. If the topic-expressing constituent contains a predicate stem, such as a verbal stem (*Vstem*), the constituent ending in that predicate stem followed by *-ru*, as in *Vstem-ru*, is nominalised by the phonologically null suffix $-\emptyset$, specified as [+NOM(INAL)]. The proposition so formed is then taken as a premise for subsequent focalisation, in which the comment constitutes the focus and the topic the background: the constituent expressing the comment is marked by the focus particle *=zo* or *=namu*, thereby yielding the focus–background structure, as represented in (5):

$$(5) [[[\dots]_{\text{COMMENT}}=zo/=namu]_{\text{FOCUS}} + [[[\dots Vstem-ru]-\emptyset]_{\text{NOMINALISED_TOPIC}}]_{\text{BACKGROUND}}]-\emptyset]_{\text{PREMISE}}$$

Thus, the information-structural complexity is different. In the *=koso* type of *kakari-musubi*, the derivation proceeds in the order 'proposition construction → premise-setting → internal focus-background structuring'. In the *=zo/=namu* type, on the other hand, the derivation proceeds in the more complex order 'topic-comment structure → proposition construction → topic-phrase nominalisation → premise-setting → internal focus-background structuring through the addition of *=zo/=namu* to the comment phrase'. Even though the proposition whose topic-expressing constituent has been nominalised is set as a premise by *-Ø* [+PREM] before the focalising operation, the intervening *-Ø* [+NOM] immediately following *-ru* prevents *-Ø* [+PREM] from standing in the local morphological relation with *-ru* that is required to trigger the allomorphy *-ru* → *-re*. Consequently, *-ru* is not realised as *-re*.

Finally, whereas the underlying form (UF) *-ru-ba* of the realis conditional form in *-re-ba*, as in *m-i-ru-ba*, surfacing as *m-i-re-ba* 'since/when one sees', contains the suffix *-ru* specified as [+ACT], the UF *-Ø-ba* of the irrealis conditional form in *-ba*, as in *m-i-Ø-ba*, surfacing as *m-i-ba* 'if one sees', contains *-Ø*, specified as [−ACT]. They therefore constitute a semantic opposition. Since *-Ø* in the latter construction, *-Ø-ba*, marks the protasis as [−ACT] through its formal opposition to *-ru*, specified as [+ACT], and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by the protasis as not yet belonging to the actual world, the following *-ba*, specified as [+COND], sets the actualisation of that eventuality itself as a hypothetical condition for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis.

Thus, the essential analytical devices employed in this account are as follows:

Functional features: [ACT], [PAST], [PREM], [COND], [CONC] and [NOM]

Informational structures: FOCUS + BACKGROUND and TOPIC + COMMENT

2. The realis form *-re* as an allomorph of the suffix *-ru*

The analysis below is based on the examples in (6) and (7), where LOC, POST, POSS, GEN, THEM, ACC, V.TH, CONJ, MNR, ESS, ADD, NEG, and FOC stand for *locative*, *postposition*, *possessor*, *genitive*, *theme*, *accusative*, *verbal thematic suffix*¹, *conjunctive*, *manner*, *essive*, *additive*, *negative* and *focus*, respectively:

(6)	<i>ike-midu=ni</i> pond-water(LOC)=POST	<i>koyohi=no</i> tonight(POSS)=GEN	<i>tuki=wo</i> moon(THEM)=ACC	<i>utusi-mo-Ø-te</i> reflect-hold-V.TH-CONJ
	<i>kokoro=no</i> mind(POSS)=GEN	<i>mama=ni</i> accordance(MNR)=POST	<i>wa=ga</i> 1sg(POSS)=GEN	<i>mono=to</i> thing(ESS)=POST
				<i>m-i-ru</i> see-V.TH-ACT

¹ For the thematic suffix, see Section 4.

'By reflecting tonight's moon in the pond water, I see it, at will, as my own.'
(Retired Emperor Shirakawa, *Kin'yō wakashū* III: 180; Kawamura et al., 2023)

(7)	<i>sira-yuki=no</i> white-snow(THEM)=GEN	<i>tokoro=mo</i> place(THEM)=ADD	<i>wak-a-zu</i> distinguish-V.TH-NEG	<i>huri-sik-Ø-e-ba</i> fall-spread-V.TH-ACT-COND
	<i>ihaho=ni=mo</i> crag(LOC)=POST=ADD	<i>sak-Ø-u</i> bloom-V.TH-ACT	<i>hana=to=koso</i> flower(ESS)=POST=FOC	<i>m-i-re</i> see-V.TH-ACT

'Since the white snow has fallen thick without distinguishing one place from another,
I see it as flowers that bloom even on crags — as flowers, precisely.'
(Kī no Akimine, *Kokin wakashū* VI: 324; Saeki, 1981)

The examples in (6) and (7) exhibit an alternation between $\boxed{Vstem-ru}$ and $\boxed{=koso \dots Vstem-re}$, as schematised in (8), where *Vstem* stands for verbal stem:

- (8) *A=wo B=to m-i-ru* '(lit.) see A as B'
*A=wo B=to=**koso** m-i-re* '(lit.) see A precisely as B'

The two forms occur after the same predicate stem *m-i-* and bear the same modal function of presenting the eventuality expressed by the proposition as belonging to the actual world. The form *-ru* occurs in the unmarked construction, whereas *-re* is contextually restricted and is correlated with — but not directly conditioned by, as discussed below — the presence of a phrase marked by the focus particle *=koso*. This complementary distribution supports the interpretation that *-re* is a contextually selected allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACTUAL-WORLD-COMMITMENT]. The morphosyntactic–semantic environment conditioning this allomorphy will be identified in Section 4.

Furthermore, the existence of the construction $\boxed{=koso \dots Vstem-re}$, in which *-re* is followed by neither *-ba* nor *-do(mo)*, demonstrates that *-re* cannot be analysed as an inseparable part of *-reba* or *-redo(mo)*. These forms must instead be segmented as *-re-ba* and *-re-do(mo)*, respectively, with *-re* constituting an allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, and *-ba* and *-do(mo)* independent suffixes.

Finally, in bigrade verbs whose V thematic suffix alternates as *-i* $\approx$ *-u* or *-e* $\approx$ *-u*, only the V thematic suffixes of the conclusive, adnominal and realis forms exhibit the alternation *-i* $\rightarrow$ *-u* or *-e* $\rightarrow$ *-u*, as in *nob-i-ba* $\approx$ *nob-i-te* $\approx$ *nob-u-Ø###* $\approx$ *nob-u-ru#NP* $\approx$ *nob-u-re-ba* $\approx$ *nob-i-yo* from the non-causative verb *nobu* 'stretch/extend' and *nob-e-ba* $\approx$ *nob-e-te* $\approx$ *nob-u-Ø###* $\approx$ *nob-u-ru#NP* $\approx$ *nob-u-re-ba* $\approx$ *nob-e-yo* from the causative verb *nobu* 'stretch/extend'. If the form *-re* in the realis forms *nob-u-re-ba* and *nob-u-re-ba* is an allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, their underlying forms are *nob-i-Ø-ba* $\approx$ *nob-i-te* $\approx$ *nob-i-ru###* $\approx$ *nob-i-ru#NP* $\approx$ *nob-i-ru-ba* $\approx$ *nob-i-yo* and *nob-e-te* $\approx$ *nob-e-ru###* $\approx$ *nob-e-ru#NP* $\approx$ *nob-e-ru-ba* $\approx$ *nob-e-yo*, respectively. The alternation *-i* $\rightarrow$ *-u* or *-e* $\rightarrow$ *-u* in the V thematic suffix can then be analysed as taking place only immediately before the underlying *-ru*, making it possible to describe this local

alternation in an extremely simple way².

3. Semantic opposition between the realis form — *izenkei* — and the irrealis form — *mizenkei* — before the conditional suffix *-ba*

In parallel with the interpretation that the form *-re* in the construction [=koso ... *Vstem-re*], as in *hana=to=koso m-i-re* 'see as flowers — as flowers, precisely' in (7), is a contextual allomorph of the suffix *-ru* found in *Vstem-ru*, as in *wa=ga mono=to m-i-ru* 'see as my own' in (6), the form *-re* in *Vstem-re-ba*, as in *m-i-re-ba* 'since/when one sees' from the verb *miru* 'look at; see', is likewise assumed to be the same contextual allomorph of the suffix *-ru* — the allomorphy being conditioned, in this case, by the following conditional suffix *-ba*.

The surface form (SF) *Vstem-re-ba*, which thus corresponds to the UF *Vstem-ru-ba*, is traditionally referred to as 'realis form (*izenkei*) + particle (*zyosi*) *-ba*' and is semantically distinct from the SF *Vstem-ba*, such as *m-i-ba* 'if one sees', which corresponds to the UF *Vstem-Ø-ba* and is traditionally referred to as 'irrealis form (*mizenkei*) + particle (*zyosi*) *-ba*', as shown in (9) and (10), where PFV, EP.NEC, NA.TH, RES, APPOS and SCOPLIM stand for *perfective*, *epistemic necessity*, *nominal-adjectival thematic suffix*, *resultative*, *apposition* and *scope-limiting*, respectively:

(9) <i>ori-Ø-te</i> break.off-V.TH-CONJ	<i>m-i-Ø-ba</i> see-V.TH-[-ACT]-COND	<i>oti-Ø=zō</i> fall-V.TH=FOC
<i>s-i-n-u-be-ki-Ø</i> do-V.TH-PFV-V.TH-EP.NEC-VA.TH-ACT	<i>aki-hagi=no</i> autumn-bush.clover(POSS)=GEN	<i>eda=mo</i> branch(THEM)=ADD
<i>tawawa-ni</i> heavily.laden-NA.TH	<i>ok-Ø-er-Ø-u</i> settle-V.TH-RES-V.TH-ACT	<i>sira-tuyu</i> white-dew(THEM)

'If I break off [a branch] and look at it, the white dew resting so heavily on the autumn bush-clover's branches that even they bend will surely fall.'
(Anonymous, *Kokin wakashū* IV: 223; Saeki, 1981)

(10) <i>tuki</i> moon(THEM)	<i>m-i-re-ba</i> see-V.TH-ACT-COND	<i>tidi-ni</i> manifold-NA.TH	<i>mono=koso</i> thing(THEM)=FOC
<i>kanasi-ke-re-Ø</i> be.sad-VA.TH-ACT-PREM	[[<i>wa=ga mi</i>] <i>hitotu</i>]= <i>no</i> [[1 sg(POSS)=GEN body(POSS)] one(APPOS)]=GEN		

² Here, in addition to the allomorphy *-ru* → *-re* / _PREMISE-SETTING ENVIRONMENT, another allomorphy, *-ru* → *-Ø* / _##, is postulated, where ## stands for a main-clause-final boundary. Since the SFs *nob-u-re-Ø/-ba/-do(mo)*, *nob-u-Ø##* and *nob-u-ru#NP* are all specified as [+ACT], the complementarily distributed forms *-re*, *-Ø* and *-ru* are assumed to be three surface exponents of the same [+ACT] morpheme.

aki=ni=wa *ar-a-ne-do*
autumn(LOC)=POST=SCOPE.LIM exist-V.TH-NEG-CONC

'When I look at the moon, things in countless ways fill me with sadness,
although it does not exist as autumn belonging to me alone'
(Ōe no Chisato, *Kokin wakashū IV*: 193; Saeki, 1981)

In the former construction *Vstem-re-ba* — underlyingly *Vstem-ru-ba* — the suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACT], first marks the protasis proposition as [+ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world. The suffix *-ba*, specified as [+COND], then sets that proposition as a premise and presents the eventuality expressed by the apodosis as following naturally from that expressed by the protasis, in the light of background knowledge comprising general knowledge, the speech situation and the preceding context. Therefore, *-ba* itself does not lexically signify cause, occasion or general condition as distinct meanings. Rather, these interpretations are assumed to be pragmatically determined by the interaction between the protasis, the apodosis and the background knowledge.

The latter construction *Vstem-ba*, on the other hand, first presents the eventuality expressed by the protasis as not belonging to the actual world and then presents the actualisation of the eventuality itself as the condition for the establishment of the eventuality expressed by the apodosis. For example, *m-i-re-ba* means 'since one sees' or 'when one sees', whereas *m-i-ba* means 'if one sees'. Note that *i-zen-* in the Japanese grammatical term *i-zen-kei* literally signifies 'already (*i-*) so (*-zen-*)', whereas *mi-zen-* in *mi-zen-kei* signifies 'not yet (*mi-*) so (*-zen-*)'.

Formally, the only difference between the UFs *Vstem-ru-ba* and *Vstem-∅-ba* is that the former contains the suffix *-ru*, whereas the latter contains *-∅* in its place. Accordingly, the suffix *-ru* in the UF *Vstem-ru-ba*, specified as [+ACT], marks the protasis proposition as [+ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world, whereas the phonologically null suffix *-∅* in the UF *Vstem-∅-ba*, specified as [−ACT], marks the protasis proposition as [−ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as not belonging to the actual world through its formal opposition to *-ru*. The structural and semantic opposition between the UFs *Vstem-ru-ba* and *Vstem-∅-ba* may be schematised as in (11):

(11)	UF		SF	Interpretation
	<i>Vstem</i>	-ru [+ACT]	<i>-ba</i> [+COND]	→ <i>Vstem-re-ba</i> cause, occasion or general condition
	<i>Vstem</i>	-∅ [−ACT]	<i>-ba</i> [+COND]	→ <i>Vstem-ba</i> hypothetical condition

In the underlying concessive construction *Vstem-ru-do(mo)*, surfacing as *Vstem-re-do(mo)* — as in *m-i-re-domo* 'although one sees', derived from the UF *m-i-ru-domo* — the suffix *-ru* presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world. The suffix *-do(mo)*, specified as

[+CONCESSIVE] or, for short, [+CONC], then presents the eventuality expressed by the apodosis as constituting a consequence contrary to what would ordinarily be expected from that expressed by the protasis. Accordingly, *-do(mo)* itself does not lexically distinguish factual from general concession. Rather, these interpretations are assumed to be pragmatically determined by the interaction between the protasis, the apodosis and the background knowledge. This structural and semantic analysis may be schematised as in (12):

(12)	UF		SF	Interpretation
	<i>Vstem -ru</i> [+ACT]	<i>-do(mo)</i> [+CONC]	→ <i>Vstem-re-do(mo)</i>	factual or general concession

4. The premise-setting environment created by *-ba*, *-do(mo)* and $\emptyset$

In the construction $[[\dots Vstem\text{-}ru]\text{-}ba]_{\text{PROTASIS}} + [\dots]_{\text{APODOSIS}}$, the protasis ending in *Vstem-ru-*, surfacing as *Vstem-re-*, constitutes the premise required for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis to stand in a causal, occasion-based or general condition–consequence relation to the eventuality expressed by the protasis, which is presented in advance as belonging to the actual world. In other words, by expressing in advance an eventuality presented as belonging to the actual world, the protasis makes it possible for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis to be placed in such a relation. Similarly, in the construction $[[\dots Vstem\text{-}ru]\text{-}do(mo)]_{\text{PROTASIS}} + [\dots]_{\text{APODOSIS}}$, the protasis ending in *Vstem-ru-*, surfacing as *Vstem-re-*, constitutes the premise required for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis to stand in a relation of factual or general concession to the eventuality expressed by the protasis, which is presented in advance as belonging to the actual world. In other words, by expressing in advance an eventuality presented as belonging to the actual world, the protasis makes it possible for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis to be placed in such a relation. Therefore, the suffixes *-ba* and *-do(mo)* have the function of presenting the protasis ending in *Vstem-ru-* as a premise. The suffix *-ru* is therefore assumed to be realised as *-re* when the proposition it marks is placed in such a premise-setting environment.

Why, then, is *-ru* realised as *-re* in the so-called *kakarimusubi* construction $[[\dots =koso] + [\dots Vstem\text{-}ru]]$, as in $[[\dots =koso] + [\dots Vstem\text{-}re]]$? In this construction, the phrase marked by the particle *=koso* constitutes the informational focus and stands in a focus–background relation to the remainder of the proposition. It may therefore be represented as $[[\dots =koso]_{\text{FOCUS}} + [\dots Vstem\text{-}re]_{\text{BACKGROUND}}]$. For a focus–background structure to be established, the proposition to which that structure applies must already have been constructed. In other words, that proposition constitutes the premise for the establishment of the focus–background structure. It follows that the entire proposition, underlyingly ending in *Vstem-ru*, is set as a premise before the focus–background structure is established, as represented in (13):

$$(13) [\dots Vstem\text{-}ru] \rightarrow [\dots Vstem\text{-}ru]_{\text{PREMISE}}$$

Thus, in the so-called *kakarimusubi* construction of this type, the proposition that the suffix *-ru* marks as [+ACT] is also placed in the same premise-setting environment, and *-ru* is therefore assumed to be realised as *-re*, as shown in

$$(14) [\dots Vstem\text{-}ru] \rightarrow [\dots Vstem\text{-}\textbf{ru}]_{\text{PREMISE}} \rightarrow [\dots Vstem\text{-}\textbf{re}]_{\text{PREMISE}}$$

Nevertheless, the element which marks the proposition $[\dots Vstem\text{-}\textbf{ru}]$ as a premise is phonologically covert. This study therefore assumes a phonologically null morpheme $-\emptyset$, specified as [+PREMISE-SETTING] or, for short, [+PREM], and posits the structure and allomorphy of *-ru* in (15):

$$(15) [\dots Vstem\text{-}ru] + -\emptyset [+PREM] \rightarrow [[\dots Vstem\text{-}\textbf{ru}]\text{-}\emptyset]_{\text{PREMISE}} \rightarrow [[\dots Vstem\text{-}\textbf{re}]\text{-}\emptyset]_{\text{PREMISE}}$$

The independently attested conditional use of bare realis forms, without *=koso* or an overt connective such as *-ba* or *-do(mo)*, as in (16), supports this analysis:

(16) <i>ipe-zakari-$\emptyset$</i> from.home-move.away-V.TH	<i>imas-$\emptyset$-u</i> go.HON-V.TH-ACT	<i>wa-g-imo=wo</i> 1sg(POSS)-GEN-beloved.woman(THEM)=ACC
<i>todom-e-kan-e</i> restrain-V.TH-be.unable-V.TH	<i>yama</i> mountain(LOC)	<i>kakusi-t-u-re-$\emptyset$</i> hide-PFV-V.TH-ACT-PREM
<i>kokoro-do=mo</i> presence.of.mind(THEM)=ADD	<i>na-si-$\emptyset$</i> be.absent-VA.TH-ACT	

'Unable to hold back my beloved wife as she departed from home,
I hid her in the mountain; consequently, I have no presence of mind.'
(Ōtomo no Yakamochi, *Man'yōshū* III: 471; Satake et al., 2013)

The bare *izenkei* construction indicates that premise-setting, and hence the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re*, is logically and historically prior to focalisation by *=koso*. Thus, a proposition was first marked as a premise by $-\emptyset$ [+PREM], with the resulting realisation of *-ru* as *-re*: *=koso* was subsequently introduced to focalise a particular constituent within that ALREADY PREMISED proposition. Ōno et al. (1990: 1497, translated from Japanese) state:

"To understand diachronically how the concord between *=koso* and the *izenkei* arose, it is first necessary to recognise that, at the earliest stage, the *izenkei* was an inflectional form capable by itself of forming a conditional protasis without *=koso*. ... Thus, the *izenkei* alone could express both a non-concessive conditional protasis meaning 'since/because ...' and a concessive conditional protasis

meaning 'although ...'. When *=koso* was introduced into a construction in which the *izenkei* already had this function, expressions of the following kind arose. ... In other words, the introduction of *=koso*, through its interaction with the *izenkei*, formed a concessive established-condition protasis. ... It was subsequently forgotten that *=koso* ... *izenkei* formed a concessive conditional protasis ...; ... *=koso* came to be introduced simply as an emphatic particle, while the *izenkei* came to be regarded as one of the ordinary means of concluding a sentence."

Interpreted within the framework of the present study, this development may be represented as follows:

1. The addition of $-\emptyset$ [+PREM] derives a premised proposition ending in the *izenkei*.
2. Depending on the context, this premised proposition receives either a [+COND] or a [+CONC] interpretation.
3. *=Koso* is introduced into a premised proposition receiving a [+CONC] interpretation, deriving a [+CONC] proposition internally structured into focus and background.
4. The [+CONC] interpretation is subsequently lost.

Accordingly, the present study's postulation of $-\emptyset$ [+PREM] and of the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re* conditioned by the premise-setting environment it provides constitutes a set of conceptual devices that succinctly accounts for the historical facts described by Ōno et al.: the historical priority of the bare *izenkei* and the secondary introduction of *=koso*.

Based on the above discussion, the morphosyntactic–semantic environments conditioning the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re* may be represented as in (17)–(19) = (1)–(3):

(17) [... *-ru*] + $-\emptyset$ [+PREMISE-SETTING]

$\rightarrow$ [... *-ru*]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

$\rightarrow$ [... *-re*]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

$\rightarrow$ [[[... *=koso*]_{FOCUS} + [... *-re*]_{BACKGROUND}]- $\emptyset$]_{PREMISE}

(18) [... *-ru*] + *-ba* [+CONDITIONAL]

$\rightarrow$ [... *-ru*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

$\rightarrow$ [... *-re*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

$\rightarrow$ [... *-re*]-*ba*]_{CONDITIONAL_PROTASIS/PREMISE} + [...]_{APODOSIS}

(19) [... **-ru**] + **-do(mo)** [+CONCESSIVE]

→ [[... **-ru**]-**do(mo)**]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [[... **-re**]-**do(mo)**]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE}

→ [[... **-re**]-**do(mo)**]_{CONCESSIVE_PROTASIS/PREMISE} + [...] _{APODOSIS}

The common conditioning environment can therefore be formulated more simply as in (20) = (4):

(20) **-ru** → **-re** / PREMISE-SETTING ENVIRONMENT: **-Ø**, **-ba**, **-do(mo)**

By contrast, in the [...] =*zo*/=*namu*] + [...] **-ru**] type of *kakari-musubi*, which ends in the adnominal form of the predicate, a proposition containing a topic–comment information structure is first constructed. If the topic-expressing constituent contains a lexically formed predicate stem, such as a verbal stem (*Vstem*), the constituent ending in that predicate stem followed by **-ru**, as in *Vstem-ru*, is nominalised by the phonologically null suffix **-Ø**, specified as [+NOM(INAL)]. The proposition so formed is then taken as a premise for subsequent focalisation, in which the comment constitutes the focus and the topic the background: the constituent expressing the comment is marked by the focus particle =*zo* or =*namu*, thereby yielding the focus–background structure, as represented in (21):

(21) [...] _{COMMENT} + [...] *Vstem-ru* _{TOPIC}

→ [...] _{COMMENT} + [...] *Vstem-ru* _{TOPIC} + **-Ø** [+NOMINAL]]

→ [...] _{COMMENT} + [...] *Vstem-ru*]-**Ø** _{NOMINALISED_TOPIC}

→ [...] _{COMMENT} + [...] *Vstem-ru*]-**Ø** _{NOMINALISED_TOPIC} + **-Ø** [+PREMISE-SETTING]

→ [[[...] _{COMMENT} + [...] *Vstem-ru*]-**Ø** _{NOMINALISED_TOPIC}]-**Ø** _{PREMISE}

→ [[[[[...] _{COMMENT} + =*zo*/=*namu*] + [...] *Vstem-ru*]-**Ø** _{NOMINALISED_TOPIC}]-**Ø** _{PREMISE}

→ [[[[[...] _{COMMENT} =*zo*/=*namu*] _{FOCUS} + [[[...] *Vstem-ru*]-**Ø** _{NOMINALISED_TOPIC} _{BACKGROUND}]-**Ø** _{PREMISE}

Thus, the information-structural complexity is different. In the =*koso* type of *kakari-musubi*, the derivation proceeds more simply in the order 'proposition construction → premise-setting → internal focus–background structuring'. This is analogous to the requirement that, within a word, prominence realised as stress can be assigned to a particular syllable only after the syllable sequence has already been determined; focus is likewise a form of prominence assigned within an already constructed proposition,

as in (22):

(22) Stress assignment: premise *import* [im.pɔ:t] → focalised ['im.pɔ:t] (noun) or [im.'pɔ:t] (verb)

In the =zo/=namu type, on the other hand, the derivation proceeds in the more complex order 'topic–comment structure → proposition construction → topic–phrase nominalisation → premise–setting → internal focus–background structuring through the addition of =zo/=namu to the comment phrase'. Even though the proposition whose topic-expressing constituent has been nominalised is set as a premise by -Ø [+PREM] before the focalising operation, the intervening -Ø [+NOM] immediately following -ru prevents -Ø [+PREM] from standing in the local morphological relation with -ru that is required to trigger the allomorphy -ru → -re. Consequently, -ru is not realised as -re³.

5. Isomorphism between verbal and verbal-adjectival realis forms (*izenkei*)

Traditionally, inflected forms of verbal adjectives (VAs) in Contemporary Japanese (CJ), such as the conjunctive form *takaku(-)* from *takai* 'be high/tall', descending from EMJ *takasi*, have been analysed as consisting of a so-called stem such as *taka-* and the so-called ending *-ku*. However, based on multiple morphosyntactic–semantic parallelisms with verbal stems (V stems), such as *tabe(-)* from the verb *taberu* 'eat', descending from EMJ *tabu*, Makino (2025) argues that *takaku(-)* as a whole functions as the stem of the verbal adjective (VA stem). As for the pseudo-stem *taka-* and the pseudo-ending *-ku*, the study analyses *taka-* as one of the two immediate constituents of the VA stem *takaku(-)*, which encodes, as a VA radical, the lexical meaning specific to the VA, and *-ku* as the other constituent, functioning as the VA thematic suffix — namely, the VA stem-forming suffix — which licences the VA radical as a syntactic constituent of the VA category at the sentential level. Thus, the VA category exhibits the basic structure '**radical + thematic suffix + ending**', which also applies to VA forms in EMJ. The study further argues that inflected forms of true verbs in CJ and EMJ show the same basic structure.

Building on that study, (23) schematises the morphosyntactic structures of selected forms of the VA *takasi* — namely, the conjunctive form *taka-ku*, the conclusive form *taka-si-Ø##*, the adnominal form *taka-ki-Ø#NP* and the realis forms *taka-ke-re-Ø*, *taka-ke-re-ba* and *taka-ke-re-do(mo)* — together with

³ The semantic difference between *haru=koso ki-nu-re* and *haru=zo ki-nu-ru* may be paraphrased in highly colloquial CJ as the opposition between *Haru=ga yat-te ki-ta=yo! Masa-ni haru=ga! Haru=ga! Haru=ga!* 'Spring has come! Precisely spring! Spring! Spring!' and *Yat-te ki-ta=yo! Haru=ga! Haru=ga! Haru=ga!* 'It has come! It is Spring! Spring! Spring!'. In the former case, the proposition 'spring has come' is already constructed and set as a premise, and then the constituent *haru* 'spring' is focalised by =koso within that proposition set as a premise. In the latter case, by contrast, *ki-nu-ru* '(it) has come', nominalised by -Ø [+NOM], constitutes the topic, and *haru=zo* '(it is) spring' supplies the comment on that nominalised topic.

their underlying forms and the corresponding forms of the V *tabu*, where Rad., Them.suff. and Infl.suff. stand for *radical*, *thematic suffix* and *inflexional suffix*, respectively:

(23)	Underlying form					Surface form				
	Stem		Ending			Stem		Ending		
	Rad.	Them.suff.	Infl.suff.	Infl.suff.		Rad.	Them.suff.	Infl.suff.	Infl.suff.	
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>				<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>			
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>				<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>			
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>	<i>-ru</i>		##	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-si</i>	<i>-Ø</i>		##
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ru</i>		##	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-Ø</i>		##
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>	<i>-ru</i>		#NP	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ki</i>	<i>-Ø</i>		#NP
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ru</i>		#NP	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-ru</i>		#NP
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-Ø</i>		<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ke</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-Ø</i>	
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-Ø</i>		<i>tab-</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-Ø</i>	
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-ba</i>		<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ke</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-ba</i>	
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-ba</i>		<i>tab-</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-ba</i>	
	<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ku</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-do(mo)</i>		<i>taka-</i>	<i>-ke</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-do(mo)</i>	
	<i>tab-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ru</i>	<i>-do(mo)</i>		<i>tab-</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>-do(mo)</i>	

The inflected forms of *takasi* and *tabu* in (23) exhibit a high degree of structural similarity. Just as the VA thematic suffix *-ku* shows the allomorphy *-ku* → *-si*, *-ki*, *-ke*, depending on the syntactic environment, the V thematic suffix *-e* also exhibits similar allomorphy, namely *-e* → *-u*. The conjunctive forms of both the VA *takasi* and the V *tabu*, *taka-ku* and *tab-e*, lack any inflexional suffix — a defining feature of the predicative stem. The suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACT], is realised as phonologically null *-Ø* in the VA conclusive form *taka-si-Ø##*, as well as in the corresponding V form *tab-u-Ø##*. Crucially for the present paper, **the suffix *-ru* is consistently realised as *-re* in premise-setting environments** — namely, **before the suffixes *-Ø* [+PREM], *-ba* [+COND] and *-do(mo)* [+CONC]** — not only in V realis forms but **also in VA realis forms**. Furthermore, the VA realis forms such as *taka-ke-re*, *taka-ke-re-ba* and *taka-ke-re-do(mo)* are the only VA inflected forms in which the suffix *-ru* is realised overtly. The existence of such forms allows us to posit the underlying structure common to the conclusive, adnominal and realis forms as *taka-ku-ru-*. The only instance in which the parallelism breaks down is in the adnominal forms *taka-ki-Ø#NP* and *tab-u-ru#NP*, but there seems to be a reason for this. In the VA *takasi*, the opposition between the conclusive and adnominal forms was maintained by the alternation of the thematic-suffix allomorphs *-si* ≈ *-ki*, as in *taka-si-Ø##* and *taka-ki-Ø#NP*, whereas in the V *tabu*, the thematic-suffix allomorph was the same in both forms, namely *-u*, and the opposition was instead maintained by the alternation of the modal-suffix allomorphs *-Ø* ≈ *-ru*, as in *tab-u-Ø##* and *tab-u-ru#NP*.

6. Feature analysis of the realis form *-sika* and the irrealis form *-se* of the past suffix *-ki*

The suffix *-ru* does not indicate whether the eventuality belongs to the past, nor whether it is affirmative or negative. It presents the eventuality represented by the proposition as belonging to the actual world and is specified as [+ACT, 0PAST], rather than [+ACT, –PAST]. Where pastness is not independently established, *-ru* and its allomorphs *-Ø* and *-re*, as in *Vstem-ru##*, *Vstem-Ø##*, *Vstem-ru#NP* and *Vstem-re-Ø/-ba/-do(mo)*, receive a non-past interpretation through their paradigmatic opposition to *-ki* and its allomorphs *-si* and *-sika*, as in *Vstem-ki##*, *Vstem-si#NP* and *Vstem-sika-Ø/-ba/-do(mo)*, which constitute portmanteau exponents of [+ACT, +PAST]. Where [+PAST] is independently supplied by another form or recoverable from the context, however, tense-neutral *-ru* can also occur with a past eventuality. The exceptional form *-se* constitutes a portmanteau exponent of [–ACT, +PAST] in *Vstem-se-ba* and shares [–ACT] with the suffix *-Ø*, specified as [–ACT, 0PAST], in *Vstem-Ø-ba*. The feature [+PAST] in *-se*, owing to the co-occurring [–ACT], cannot anchor a past eventuality in the actual world. Consequently, [+PAST] is reinterpreted as [+IRREAL] through the other-world value in the binary world-opposition schema ACTUAL WORLD vs. OTHER WORLD, giving rise to a counterfactual reading. Therefore, the semantic oppositions between *mi-re-ba*, *mi-sika-ba*, *mi-Ø-ba* and *mi-se-ba* from the verb *miru* 'look at' can be analysed as demonstrated in (24):

(24)

	[ACT]	[PAST]	[COND]	Interpretation
<i>mi-re-ba</i>	+	0	+	actual-world cause, occasion or general condition: 'since/when/whenever one sees'
<i>mi-sika-ba</i>	+	+	+	actual-world past cause or occasion ⁴ : 'since/when one saw'
<i>mi-Ø-ba</i>	–	0	+	hypothetical condition: 'if one sees'
<i>mi-se-ba</i>	–	+	+	counterfactual condition: 'if one saw/were to see; if one had seen'

Note that the suffix *-ki* is said to be often used to 'express the memory of one's own experience' (Ōno et al. 1990: 1481, translated from Japanese). This may be because direct experience constitutes the most immediate epistemic ground for attributing a past eventuality to the actual world, and therefore typically licenses *-ki*, specified as [+ACT, +PAST].

7. Reanalysis of the suffix–suffix sequence *-re-ba* into the single conditional suffix *-reba*

In EMJ, the morphosyntactic–semantic opposition in (25) was still maintained:

⁴ A past general-condition interpretation is not logically excluded, but no unambiguous attestation has yet been identified.

- (25) UF *yom-Ø-Ø*_[-ACT]-*ba* → SF *yom-a-Ø-ba* 'if one reads'
 UF *yom-Ø-ru*_[+ACT]-*ba* → IF *yom-Ø-re-ba* → SF *yom-Ø-e-ba* 'since/when one reads'

However, in the course of the development towards CJ, in accordance with the tendency for the V thematic suffix *-Ø* to be realised, in principle, as phonologically null, forms containing its allomorph *-a*, such as *yom-a-Ø-ba*, fell out of use, except in fixed expressions such as *suki ar-a-Ø-ba* 'given half a chance' and literary expressions such as *sin-a-Ø-ba moro=tomo* 'if we die, let us die together'. As a result, the productive morphosyntactic–semantic opposition between the realis conditional form in *-re*_[+ACT]-*ba* and the irrealis conditional form in *-Ø*_[-ACT]-*ba* was lost. Once *-re* no longer had its productive oppositional counterpart *-Ø*, specified as [-ACT], within the conditional paradigm, it also lost its semantic value [+ACT]. This is because linguistic value arises from opposition, as Saussure (1916: 187, 196) puts it: "Dans l'intérieur d'une même langue, tous les mots qui expriment des idées voisines se limitent réciproquement ... n'ont de valeur propre que par leur opposition"; "deux signes comportant chacun un signifié et un signifiant ... sont seulement distincts. Entre eux il n'y a qu'opposition. Tout le mécanisme du langage ... repose sur des oppositions de ce genre et sur les différences phoniques et conceptuelles qu'elles impliquent".

Having lost its semantic value, *-re* was no longer recognised as an independent morpheme and, owing to the resulting opacity of the morpheme boundary, merged with the following *-ba* to form the single morpheme *-reba*. This is the CJ conditional suffix *-reba*. Since the reanalysed *-reba* has lost the [+ACT] component originally possessed by *-re* as an allomorph of *-ru*, its meaning has changed from [+ACT, +COND] to [+COND]. Consequently, although it may still receive an actual-world causal, occasional or general-condition interpretation where this is contextually supported, it no longer marks such an interpretation through a [+ACT] component and has become available for hypothetical conditions. The derivation of the SF *yomeba* in EMJ and CJ can be schematised as in (26):

- (26) EMJ: UF *yom-Ø-ru-ba* → IF *yom-Ø-re-ba* → SF *yom-Ø-e-ba* 'since/when one reads'
 CJ: UF *yom-Ø-reba* → SF *yom-Ø-e-ba* 'if one reads'

This diachronic scenario awaits fuller philological verification, but it appears to provide a coherent account of the reanalysis of *-re-ba* into CJ *-reba*.

8. Conclusion

This study has argued that the suffixal form *-re* in the EMJ realis paradigm — the so-called *izenkei* — is not an independent inflexional morpheme, but an allomorph of the suffix *-ru*, specified as [+ACTUAL-WORLD-COMMITMENT, 0PAST]. The suffix *-ru* marks a proposition as [+ACT] and thereby presents the eventuality expressed by that proposition as belonging to the actual world. It surfaces as *-re* when the

proposition marked by *-ru* is placed in a premise-setting environment. The allomorphy may therefore be formulated as in (27):

$$(27) -ru [+ACT, 0PAST] \rightarrow -re [+ACT, 0PAST] / \text{PREMISE-SETTING-ENVIRONMENT: } : -\emptyset, -ba, -do(mo)$$

In the conditional and concessive constructions, this environment is created respectively by the suffixes *-ba* [+COND] and *-do(mo)* [+CONC], which set the protasis as the premise required for the eventuality expressed by the apodosis to stand in the relevant relation to the eventuality expressed by the protasis, the latter being presented in advance as belonging to the actual world. In the *=koso* type of *kakari-musubi*, the same function is performed by the phonologically null suffix $-\emptyset$, specified as [+PREM]. Therefore, the particle *=koso* does not itself condition the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re*, but focalises a constituent within an already constructed proposition set as a premise. In the *=zo/=namu* type of *kakari-musubi*, by contrast, a topic-comment proposition is first constructed, and a predicate-containing topic constituent is nominalised by $-\emptyset$ [+NOM(INAL)]. The proposition is then set as a premise by a further $-\emptyset$ [+PREM], after which *=zo* or *=namu* focalises the comment phrase. Although the proposition is thus set as a premise, the intervening $-\emptyset$ [+NOM] immediately following *-ru* blocks the local morphological relation between *-ru* and $-\emptyset$ [+PREM] required to trigger the allomorphy *-ru* $\rightarrow$ *-re*. Consequently, *-ru* is not realised as *-re*.

The analysis also accounts for the opposition between *Vstem-ru-ba* [+ACT, +COND] and *Vstem- $\emptyset$ -ba* [-ACT, +COND], and situates this opposition within the wider feature system that also includes *-sika* [+ACT, +PAST] and *-se* [-ACT, +PAST] in the environment *Vstem_-ba*. Moreover, the morphosyntactic parallelism between verbal and verbal-adjectival realis forms supports the underlying presence of the same suffix *-ru* in structures such as *tab-e-ru-* and *taka-ku-ru-*. The realis forms of verbs and verbal adjectives can thus be treated as instantiations of one and the same underlying structure and one and the same process of allomorphy same allomorphic process.

Finally, the loss of the productive opposition between *-re*_[+ACT]-*ba* and *- $\emptyset$* _[-ACT]-*ba* is proposed to have deprived *-re* of its oppositional value [+ACT]. The resulting semantic and morphological opacity allowed *-re-ba* to be reanalysed as the single conditional suffix *-reba*, specified only as [+COND] and, consequently, available for hypothetical conditions. Although this diachronic scenario requires fuller philological verification, the proposed analysis appears to provide a unified account of the morphosyntax, semantics and subsequent development of the EMJ *izenkei*.

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